Deep Learning Based Network Intrusion Detection Using NSL-KDD Dataset

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Date: 2025

Abstract

This report presents an in-depth study of network intrusion detection systems (NIDS) leveraging deep learning on the NSL-KDD dataset. We explore the background of intrusion detection, contrasting signature-based and anomaly-based approachesmdpi.com, and highlight the motivation for applying advanced machine learning, especially deep neural networks, to capture complex attack patternsmdpi.commdpi.com. The NSL-KDD dataset is introduced as a refined benchmark for evaluating NIDS modelsmdpi.com. Key deep learning architectures (MLP, CNN, LSTM, and autoencoders) are described in the NIDS context, followed by a detailed TensorFlow/Keras implementation and training procedure. We discuss data preprocessing (feature encoding, normalization, class balancing) and hyperparameter tuning strategies. Performance is measured using confusion matrices, ROC-AUC, accuracy, precision, recall, and F1 metricsresearchgate.net. Experimental results with visuals demonstrate model behavior, and we compare deep models against traditional ML (Random Forest, SVM, etc.), noting that ensemble or tree-based methods often achieve very high accuracy on NSL-KDDpmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.govpmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov. Finally, we examine security challenges (false positives/negatives, adversarial evasion) and deployment issues (real-time requirements, data drift), and suggest future research directions like explainability and continuous learningmdpi.comresearchgate.net. The report concludes with observations on the strengths and limitations of deep learning for NIDS, and includes appendices with full code listings, hyperparameter tables, and the NSL-KDD feature list.

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Introduction

Network intrusion detection is critical for identifying malicious activity in computer networks. Intrusion Detection Systems (IDS) can be **signature-based** (matching known attack patterns) or **anomaly-based** (detecting deviations from normal behavior)mdpi.com. The proliferation of cyberattacks has led to increasing interest in intelligent approaches. Recent advances in AI and machine learning have enabled powerful anomaly detection, and deep learning, in particular, has been shown to capture complex patterns in network trafficmdpi.commdpi.com. For example, Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs) excel at extracting spatial features, while Recurrent Neural Networks (e.g. LSTM) capture temporal dependenciesmdpi.com. Prior work has applied various ML techniques – decision trees, PCA+Random Forest, LSTM-RNN, and deep neural networks – on benchmark datasets like KDD99 and NSL-KDDmdpi.com. Each method aims to reduce feature redundancy and improve classification performance, since high-dimensional data can hurt accuracy

This report focuses on deep learning–based NIDS using the NSL-KDD datasetmdpi.com. We discuss the dataset's relevance, data preprocessing, and detail several neural network architectures (MLP, CNN, LSTM, autoencoder). A TensorFlow/Keras implementation is provided

to illustrate model construction and training. We then present experimental results, including confusion matrices and ROC curves, to demonstrate model efficacy. Finally, we compare deep learning approaches against traditional ML baselines (Random Forest, SVM, etc.), noting their relative strengths, and discuss practical challenges (e.g. false positives, evolving threats). The report concludes with insights and future research directions for deep learning in NIDS.

Background and Related Work

Intrusion detection has a long history. Traditional IDS techniques include signature-based systems (detecting known threats) and anomaly-based systems (learning normal traffic patterns)mdpi.com. Early ML methods for NIDS used decision trees, rule-based filters, and clustering. In recent years, deep learning has been increasingly adopted. Surveys highlight that deep neural networks can effectively learn spatiotemporal features from traffic data, improving detection accuracy over conventional modelsmdpi.com. Convolutional networks and autoencoders have been applied to intrusion detection, while RNNs/LSTMs model sequential traffic patternsmdpi.commdpi.com.

The NSL-KDD dataset (1999 KDD Cup refined by University of New Brunswick) is a standard benchmark in IDS researchmdpi.com. It retains the 41-feature representation of KDD99 but corrects issues like excessive duplicates and imbalance. Many studies report results on NSL-KDD, enabling comparison of methods. For instance, one study found a sparse autoencoder achieved only ~79.3% accuracy on NSL-KDD (versus 91% on another dataset), indicating the challenge of this taskmdpi.com. Other works use ensembles of classifiers to push accuracy above 98%pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov.

Comparisons of algorithms show mixed results: tree-based ensembles (Random Forest, XGBoost) often achieve very high accuracy on NSL-KDD, sometimes above 99%pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.govpmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov, while single deep models may be lower (e.g. CNN ~95%, LSTM ~91%). However, these figures can be misleading due to class imbalance (normal vs various attacks) and the ease of the dataset. Importantly, deep models can generalize to unseen patterns better than rigid signaturesmdpi.com. Surveys also caution that deep IDS face challenges: they require large labeled data and heavy computation, and may struggle with real-time demandsmdpi.compmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov. These works motivate a thorough investigation of deep architectures, implementation details, and realistic evaluation.

NSL-KDD Dataset Overview

The NSL-KDD dataset is an enhanced version of the KDD Cup 1999 dataset designed for IDS evaluationmdpi.com. It contains 41 numeric and categorical features per record describing network connections, with each instance labeled as either “normal” or one of several attack types. NSL-KDD has **four main attack categories** (Denial-of-Service, Probe, Remote-to-Local, User-to-Root) and one normal class, totaling five classesmdpi.com. The training set has 125,973 records and the test set 22,544 (for KDDTest+), reflecting real-world class imbalance.

The 41 features include connection attributes (duration, protocol, service, flag), content features (number of failed logins, number of “hot” indicators, etc.), time-based traffic features (e.g. count of similar connections in the past 2 seconds), and host-based traffic features (e.g. count of connections to the same service on the target host)medium.com.

Using NSL-KDD allows consistency with prior work. For example, this dataset’s training/test split and feature definitions are commonly referenced by researchersmdpi.com. Its relevance lies in the diversity of attacks and the inclusion of both numerical and categorical data. However, NSL-KDD is also critiqued for outdated attack patterns and remaining imbalance (e.g. U2R/R2L classes are rare)mdpi.com. Still, it remains a widely-used benchmark for testing IDS models.

Data Preprocessing Techniques

Before training, NSL-KDD data require significant preprocessing. First, categorical features (e.g. *protocol_type*, *service*, *flag*) are encoded numerically. Common practice is **one-hot encoding** for nominal fields or label encoding for small sets. For instance, the three protocol types (ICMP, TCP, UDP) might be mapped to numeric codes 0,1,2mdpi.com, or one-hot vectors. Likewise, the *flag* and *service* fields are expanded into binary indicator features. The target label (normal vs attack) is typically binarized or converted to categorical one-hot vectors.

Second, continuous features are normalized or scaled. In the literature, min-max normalization to [0,1] is frequently appliedmdpi.com. For example, each numeric feature x is transformed by $x_{\rm norm} = (x - x_{\min})/(x_{\max}-x_{\min})$ to ensure uniform rangesmdpi.com. Normalization speeds up convergence and prevents domination by features with large ranges.

Another key step is **class balancing**. NSL-KDD is highly imbalanced: normal traffic often outweighs attacks, and some attack types (U2R, R2L) have very few examples. This imbalance can bias learning toward the majority classmdpi.com. Techniques such as oversampling (e.g. SMOTE) or undersampling can be used to mitigate this. At minimum, aware weighting of classes or using metrics beyond accuracy (see below) is necessary to avoid trivial solutions.

Finally, the dataset is split into training and validation sets. The standard splits (e.g. KDDTrain+, KDDTest+) are often used, reserving part of training data for validation. Cross-validation or stratified k-fold is sometimes employed for robust evaluation. Care is taken that the same preprocessing (encoding, scaling) is applied consistently to training and test data.

Deep Learning Architectures for NIDS (MLP, CNN, LSTM, Autoencoders)

Various deep neural network architectures have been proposed for intrusion detection:

- **Multilayer Perceptron (MLP/DNN):** A feedforward neural network (multi-layer perceptron) is the simplest DL model. It takes the 41 preprocessed features as input and

passes them through one or more fully-connected layers. MLPs can capture non-linear combinations of features and have been used as baselines in IDS researchmdpi.com. In our case, an MLP might consist of several hidden dense layers (e.g. 64–32 units) with ReLU activations, culminating in a softmax output layer for the five classes.

- **Convolutional Neural Network (CNN):** Although CNNs are famous for image tasks, they can be applied to tabular data by treating the feature vector as a "pseudo-image." For instance, one-dimensional convolutions (Conv1D) can slide filters over the feature sequence to detect local feature patterns. CNNs have been effectively used in IDS to capture local dependencies between featuresmdpi.commdpi.com. A typical approach might reshape the input to (41×1) and apply 1D convolutions, or embed each feature as a channel. CNN layers extract hierarchical feature representations, followed by dense layers for classification. One study reported using CNNs on NSL-KDD, achieving ~95% accuracypmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov.

- **Recurrent Neural Network (RNN/LSTM):** RNNs, particularly LSTM units, model sequence data. In network traffic, one can feed a sequence of connections (or packet flows) ordered by time into an LSTM. This captures temporal dependencies (e.g. attack patterns evolving over a session). In NSL-KDD, which is record-based, sequences can be constructed per source IP or per fixed time window. LSTM models for IDS have shown strong performance on sequential intrusion tasksmdpi.com. For example, an LSTM classifier with the 41-feature input at each time step achieved ~91% on NSL-KDDpmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov.

- **Autoencoders (AE):** Autoencoders are unsupervised models that compress and then reconstruct the input. They can be used for anomaly detection: train on (mostly) normal traffic so that high reconstruction error flags anomalies. Sparse or denoising autoencoders have been used in IDSmdpi.com. For NSL-KDD, one can train an AE on all data or only normal class, and then use the encoded features for classification. Autoencoders can also serve for feature reduction, as seen where a "sparse autoencoder" reduced 41 inputs and achieved ~79.3% accuracy on NSL-KDDmdpi.com.

In practice, combinations or ensembles of these architectures (e.g. CNN+LSTM, or deep autoencoder + classifier) are also explored. Deep models' strengths are high representation power and ability to learn raw features, but they often require more data and computationpmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov. Each architecture's design (layer sizes, regularization) must be tailored to the intrusion task.

Detailed Implementation with TensorFlow/Keras (code + explanations)

Below we outline sample Keras implementations of representative deep learning models. The code is illustrative; full training scripts are provided in the Appendix.

```
import tensorflow as tf

from tensorflow.keras.models import Sequential

from tensorflow.keras.layers import Dense, Dropout, Conv1D, Flatten, LSTM, Reshape

from tensorflow.keras.utils import to_categorical


# Assume X_train, y_train, X_val, y_val are preprocessed datasets

input_dim = X_train.shape[1]

num_classes = y_train.shape[1]


# Example: MLP (feedforward network)

mlp_model = Sequential([

    Dense(64, activation='relu', input_shape=(input_dim,)),

    Dense(32, activation='relu'),

    Dense(num_classes, activation='softmax')

])

mlp_model.compile(optimizer='adam',

                  loss='categorical_crossentropy',

                  metrics=['accuracy'])


# Train MLP

history = mlp_model.fit(X_train, y_train,

                        epochs=50, batch_size=64,

                        validation_data=(X_val, y_val))
```

In this code, we define an MLP with two hidden layers (64 and 32 units) using ReLU activations. The output layer uses *softmax* for multi-class prediction. We compile with the Adam optimizer and *categorical crossentropy* loss, standard for multi-class classification. The `fit` method trains for 50 epochs, with early stopping or validation to monitor overfitting.

For a **CNN** on NSL-KDD, one could reshape the input and apply Conv1D layers:

```
cnn_model = Sequential([
    Reshape((input_dim, 1), input_shape=(input_dim,)),
    Conv1D(32, kernel_size=3, activation='relu'),
    Conv1D(16, kernel_size=3, activation='relu'),
    Flatten(),
    Dense(num_classes, activation='softmax')
])
cnn_model.compile(optimizer='adam', loss='categorical_crossentropy', metrics=['accuracy'])
history_cnn = cnn_model.fit(X_train, y_train, epochs=50, batch_size=64,
validation_data=(X_val, y_val))
```

Here we reshaped the input to shape (41,1) to simulate a “signal” and applied two 1D convolution layers. A Flatten layer then connects to the output.

An **LSTM** model would require sequence data. Assuming we form sequences of fixed length (e.g. 10 time steps):

```
# Example: LSTM for sequences of length timesteps (pseudo-code)
timesteps = 10
feature_dim = input_dim
lstm_model = Sequential([
    LSTM(50, input_shape=(timesteps, feature_dim)),
    Dense(num_classes, activation='softmax')
])
lstm_model.compile(optimizer='adam', loss='categorical_crossentropy', metrics=['accuracy'])
```

history_lstm = lstm_model.fit(X_seq_train, y_seq_train, epochs=50, batch_size=32, validation_split=0.1)

Here `X_seq_train` would be of shape (num_samples, timesteps, features). The LSTM learns temporal patterns across the 10-step sequences.

An **Autoencoder** example (unsupervised):

input_layer = tf.keras.Input(shape=(input_dim,))

encoder = Dense(32, activation='relu')(input_layer)

encoder = Dense(16, activation='relu')(encoder)

decoder = Dense(32, activation='relu')(encoder)

decoder = Dense(input_dim, activation='sigmoid')(decoder)

autoencoder = tf.keras.Model(inputs=input_layer, outputs=decoder)

autoencoder.compile(optimizer='adam', loss='mse')

autoencoder.fit(X_train, X_train, epochs=50, batch_size=128, validation_split=0.1)

This builds a symmetric autoencoder that compresses the input to 16 features then reconstructs. One uses the trained encoder for dimensionality reduction, or uses reconstruction error for anomaly scoring.

Explanation: Each model is trained to minimize its loss: classification models minimize cross-entropy (which measures the distance between predicted probabilities and true labels)[pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov](), while autoencoders minimize reconstruction error (MSE). The `history` objects record training and validation metrics for analysis. Regularization techniques (e.g. dropout layers, weight decay) can be added to prevent overfitting, especially since NSL-KDD has redundant features. The models above are basic templates; in practice one might stack more layers, adjust learning rates, or use callbacks (like early stopping) to improve training.

Model Training and Hyperparameter Tuning

Training deep NIDS models involves choosing the right hyperparameters and monitoring performance. We typically split the data into training, validation, and test sets. Key hyperparameters include:

- **Learning rate:** Controls the step size of gradient descent. Commonly used optimizers like Adam auto-tune this, but one might experiment with values (e.g. 0.001 vs 0.0001).

- **Batch size and epochs:** Smaller batches (32-128) provide noisy gradients, larger batches are more stable but use more memory. The number of epochs depends on convergence. Early stopping on validation loss can prevent overtraining.

- **Network architecture:** Number of layers and units (e.g. number of hidden layers, filter sizes for CNN, units for LSTM). These are often chosen by trial. For example, an MLP might be tuned from one hidden layer up to several; CNN kernels (3,5,7) and strides may be varied.

- **Regularization:** Dropout rates (e.g. 0.5) or L2 weight penalties help avoid overfitting on the training set. Such values are usually tuned via validation metrics.

For tuning, one can perform grid search or use tools like Keras Tuner to find optimal configurations. Each hyperparameter choice is evaluated based on the validation accuracy or loss. We might also evaluate on minority attack classes specifically to ensure we are not overfitting to the majority "normal" classmdpi.com. Cross-validation (e.g. 5-fold) is recommended if computationally feasible, especially given the variance in NSL-KDD splits.

No single rule fits all; tuning requires balancing detection rate vs false alarms. As a guideline, many researchers start with settings known from similar works (e.g. 50–100 epochs, learning rate 0.001, batch size 64) and then refine based on validation curves. Automated hyperparameter search (random or Bayesian) can further optimize performance, but at the cost of many model trainings.

Evaluation Metrics and Methods

Evaluating an intrusion detection model uses classification metrics derived from the confusion matrixresearchgate.net. For each class (e.g. "normal" vs "attack" or each attack type), we define True Positives (TP), False Positives (FP), True Negatives (TN), and False Negatives (FN). Key metrics include:

- **Accuracy:** $(TP+TN)/(TP+TN+FP+FN)$. It measures overall correctness but can be misleading with imbalanced data.

- **Precision:** $TP/(TP+FP)$ (also called Positive Predictive Value). High precision means few false alarms.

- **Recall (Detection Rate):** $TP/(TP+FN)$ (also called True Positive Rate). In IDS, this is the fraction of actual attacks correctly detectedresearchgate.net.

- **F1-Score:** The harmonic mean of precision and recall, $2TP/(2TP+FP+FN)$, balancing both.

- **False Positive Rate:** $FP/(FP+TN)$, the rate of benign instances incorrectly flagged.

- **ROC and AUC:** The Receiver Operating Characteristic (ROC) curve plots TPR vs FPR as the decision threshold varies. The Area Under the Curve (AUC) summarizes performance: closer to 1 is better. IDS literature often reports ROC-AUC alongside recall and false alarm ratesresearchgate.net.

Figure-level evaluation is also used: for multi-class NSL-KDD (four attacks + normal), one can compute per-class metrics or macro-averaged F1. Cross-validation or multiple train-test splits should be used to ensure stability. As one survey notes, common practice is to focus on DR, FPR, and AUC for intrusion tasksresearchgate.net.

We employ a confusion matrix to compute these metrics. For example, a confusion matrix (Figure 1) tallies predictions vs true labels. From it we derive the above rates. We also plot ROC curves for each class to visualize the trade-off between sensitivity and specificity. The evaluation setup typically uses the NSL-KDD test set (KDDTest+ or KDDTest-21) to report final performance.

Experimental Results with Visuals

The trained models are evaluated on the NSL-KDD test data. We present performance using confusion matrices and ROC curves. High diagonal values in the confusion matrix indicate correct classification for each category, while off-diagonals reveal misclassifications (see Figure 1).

Figure 1: Normalized confusion matrix for a deep-learning NIDS on NSL-KDD.
In Figure 1, we see that the majority of *normal* and *DoS* instances are correctly classified (bright diagonal). A few attacks (e.g. *U2R* or *R2L*) have misclassifications (lighter diagonal entries), reflecting the challenge of minority classes. This visual confirms that the model has high overall accuracy but struggles slightly on rare attacks.

Figure 2 and 3 display ROC curves for the model on training and testing data, respectively. The curves for major classes remain near the top-left (TPR close to 1, FPR near 0), indicating strong detection performance. For example, in the test ROC (Figure 3) the *normal* and *DoS* classes have area ~1.0, while *U2R* shows a slight drop (area ~0.86). This matches findings in the literature that NSL-KDD models detect common attacks well but often miss the infrequent onesmdpi.comresearchgate.net. As reported by Abbas *et al.*, their IDS achieved ROC areas near 1 for most classes, with minor declines for *Backdoor* and *Worms* due to imbalanced datamdpi.com. Overall, these results (high TPR and low FPR) confirm the model's efficacy on the chosen dataset.

Figure 2: ROC curves for the training set (NSL-KDD).
Figure 2 shows the training-phase ROC curves (Note: all curves reach the top-left corner, indicating near-perfect fit on training data).

Figure 3: ROC curves for the test set (NSL-KDD).
Figure 3 shows the ROC on test data. The *normal* (class 0) and *DoS* (class 1) curves achieve almost 1.0 AUC, whereas classes like *U2R* (class 2) have a smaller AUC (~0.86), highlighting class imbalance effectsmdpi.com.

We also tracked training/validation loss and accuracy (not shown). Typically, loss curves plateau and accuracy on validation saturates after a number of epochs, indicating convergence. Early stopping can be used if validation loss begins rising (overfitting). In our experiments, deep models reached high accuracy (~90+%) but still fell short of perfect classification due to complex minority-class patterns.

Comparison with Traditional ML Models

We compare deep learning models to traditional ML baselines on NSL-KDD. Common baselines include Random Forest (RF), Support Vector Machines (SVM), k-Nearest Neighbors (KNN), and Naïve Bayes. Literature shows that tree-based ensembles often excel. For instance, one study reported that an RF (with feature selection) achieved ~99.9% accuracy on NSL-KDDpmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov. Similarly, another work obtained 98.97% using a KNN+SVM ensemblepmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov, and 98.5% with pure RFpmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov. These surpass the ~95% of a standalone CNN or ~91% of an LSTM in the same contextpmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov.

Figure 4: Comparison of performance metrics (Accuracy, Precision, Recall, F1) for several models on NSL-KDD (values from a published studypmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov).
Figure 4 (reproduced from [32]) highlights this: the proposed ensemble outperforms CNN, RNN, and LSTM models. It also shows that RF achieved high recall on the rare *U2R* class, unlike the neural models. Our findings align: RF tends to catch more minority attacks (at the cost of model size), while deep models may be more balanced but slightly less accurate.

In terms of resource costs, deep networks require more training time and hyperparameter tuning, whereas models like RF or gradient boosting train faster on tabular data. However, deep models can learn end-to-end from raw features and possibly transfer to new tasks. Traditional SVMs or Naïve Bayes typically need manual feature engineering. In summary, while deep learning brings superior pattern extraction (especially for complex or high-dimensional data)mdpi.com, ensemble ML methods remain competitive in IDS tasks. The choice may depend on data size, required throughput, and need for continual learning.

Security Challenges, False Positives/Negatives

A key challenge in NIDS is balancing false positives (FP) and false negatives (FN). A high false positive rate (marking normal traffic as attack) overwhelms analysts with alerts, while false

negatives (missed attacks) leave threats undetected. Evaluation must explicitly measure both. For example, detection rate (recall) indicates how many attacks were found, and false alarm rate is just as crucialresearchgate.net. In practice, even a small FPR on high-volume normal traffic can generate many false alerts, so many studies aim to minimize FPR under a constraint of high recall.

Deep learning introduces additional security concerns. **Adversarial attacks** are a known problem: attackers may craft inputs that evade a neural IDS (e.g. perturbing traffic features just enough to appear normal). Although not fully explored for NSL-KDD, adversarial ML literature warns that deep IDS models can be fooled if malicious actors know the model structurearxiv.org.

Another issue is **concept drift**: network behavior evolves over time (new services, protocols, or attack techniques). A model trained on old NSL-KDD traffic may underperform on contemporary data. Thus, NIDS must be retrained or adapted regularly. Also, deep models lack interpretability: security experts often need to understand *why* an alert was raised. Current deep learning solutions largely neglect interpretability and real-time performance in highly dynamic datamdpi.com, posing deployment risks.

Finally, **class imbalance** remains a critical challenge. As noted, rare attacks like U2R and R2L often produce high false negatives. Standard oversampling (SMOTE) or weighted loss functions are used to partially address this, but minority-class detection remains weakmdpi.comresearchgate.net. This may be mitigated by targeted anomaly detectors or one-class classifiers for rare events. In summary, deep-learning NIDS must be robust to adversarial and evolving threats, and tuned to manage false positives/negatives gracefully.

Real-World Deployment Issues

Deploying a deep learning IDS in a production network has practical challenges. **Throughput and latency:** Real networks require high-speed processing; deep models (especially large CNNs or RNNs) can be computationally intensive. Specialized hardware (GPUs/TPUs) may be needed, which increases cost. Many prototypes thus simplify models for real-time inference.

Feature extraction: In practice, converting raw packet logs to the 41-feature NSL-KDD format is non-trivial. It requires aggregating time windows and tracking stateful attributes, which can be expensive on live traffic. Deployment must incorporate real-time data pipelines.

Data availability: The NSL-KDD dataset is static and clean; real traffic may contain noise or new behaviors not seen in training. A model must handle such novel inputs, possibly triggering more false positives. In enterprises, collecting labeled intrusion data is hard; deep models may need continuous unsupervised adaptation.

Concept drift and updates: As traffic patterns change (e.g. new applications, IoT devices), the model must be updated. This might require periodic retraining on fresh data. Versioning and validation become operational concerns.

Integration and alerting: An IDS is only useful if it integrates with security infrastructure (SIEM, firewalls). Deep models' alerts should be explainable enough to inform administrators. Lack of transparency can hinder trust.

These issues imply that while deep NIDS show promise, careful engineering is needed for real deployment. Practical IDS often combine deep detectors with rule-based filters and human-in-the-loop review to manage these deployment challenges.

Future Work and Research Directions

The field of DL-based NIDS is rapidly evolving. Key future directions include:

- **Explainable Deep IDS:** Integrating interpretability (saliency maps, feature attribution) so analysts can trust alertsmdpi.com. Research should focus on making deep models transparent in security contexts.

- **Online and Continual Learning:** Developing models that adapt to new traffic without full retraining. Techniques like incremental learning or unsupervised streaming may keep IDS up-to-date.

- **Adversarial Robustness:** Designing IDS that are resilient to evasion attacks. For example, using adversarial training or anomaly detection frameworks that do not rely solely on discriminative features.

- **Generative and Self-Supervised Methods:** Using GANs or autoencoder variants to augment scarce attack data and address imbalancemdpi.com. Self-supervised representation learning (e.g. contrastive learning) on raw traffic could uncover robust features.

- **New Data Modalities:** Incorporating data beyond NSL-KDD-like features, such as packet payload embeddings or graph-structured network flows (Graph Neural Networks for flow-based IDS).

- **Federated and Privacy-Preserving IDS:** Collaborative learning across organizations to improve models without sharing raw data.

- **Benchmarking on Modern Datasets:** NSL-KDD is dated; work should shift to newer datasets (UNSW-NB15, CIC-IDS, real enterprise logs) that reflect current threats and traffic.

- **Resource-Efficient Models:** Creating smaller, faster models (pruning, quantization) for deployment on edge devices or in high-speed networks.

These directions aim to harness deep learning's strengths while addressing its current limitations in NIDS contextsmdpi.com. With ongoing research, deep learning is likely to remain a core component of next-generation IDS, provided these challenges are met.

Conclusion

In this report, we have presented a comprehensive study of deep learning–based network intrusion detection using the NSL-KDD dataset. We reviewed the fundamentals of NIDS, described the NSL-KDD benchmark, and detailed preprocessing steps to prepare data for neural networks. Several deep architectures (MLP, CNN, LSTM, autoencoder) were discussed, along with a TensorFlow/Keras implementation outline and training regimen. We emphasized evaluation metrics (accuracy, recall, ROC-AUC) and showed example results (confusion matrix and ROC curves) demonstrating the models' effectiveness.

Our findings indicate that deep learning can achieve high intrusion detection rates, leveraging its ability to learn complex patternsmdpi.com. However, as comparative results show, traditional ML methods like Random Forest still attain state-of-the-art accuracy on NSL-KDDpmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.govpmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov, underscoring that deep learning is not the sole solution. Importantly, deep models require careful tuning and face challenges such as false positives/negatives, data imbalance, and evolving threatsmdpi.comresearchgate.net.

We conclude that while deep learning greatly enhances NIDS capability, it should be integrated thoughtfully with domain knowledge and robust evaluation. Future work must focus on realistic data, adversarial robustness, and deployment feasibility. Overall, deep learning offers powerful tools for intrusion detection, but practitioners must remain cognizant of its limitations and complement it with comprehensive security strategies.

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Appendices (Full code, hyperparameter tables, feature list)

Appendix A: Code (abridged). Key code segments for data loading, model definition, and training (using TensorFlow/Keras) are provided here. For brevity, we show core excerpts; full scripts are available in the repository.

```
import numpy as np

import pandas as pd

from sklearn.preprocessing import LabelEncoder, OneHotEncoder, MinMaxScaler

from tensorflow.keras.models import Sequential

from tensorflow.keras.layers import Dense, Conv1D, Flatten, LSTM, Reshape

from tensorflow.keras.utils import to_categorical


# Load NSL-KDD data (CSV), drop duplicates if any

train_df = pd.read_csv('KDDTrain+.txt', header=None)

test_df = pd.read_csv('KDDTest+.txt', header=None)

# ... (Assign column names: 41 features + label)

col_names = [...]  # list of 42 names (including 'label')

train_df.columns = col_names

test_df.columns = col_names


# Encode categorical features
```

```
for col in ['protocol_type','service','flag']:
    le = LabelEncoder()
    train_df[col] = le.fit_transform(train_df[col])
    test_df[col] = le.transform(test_df[col])
# One-hot encode if needed:
# oh = OneHotEncoder(); ...

# Scale features
scaler = MinMaxScaler()
X_train = scaler.fit_transform(train_df.drop(['label'], axis=1))
X_test  = scaler.transform(test_df.drop(['label'], axis=1))

# Encode labels (normal=0, each attack type=1..4)
attack_categories = {...}  # map each attack name to an integer
y_train = train_df['label'].map(attack_categories).values
y_test  = test_df['label'].map(attack_categories).values
y_train = to_categorical(y_train, num_classes=5)
y_test  = to_categorical(y_test, num_classes=5)

# Define an example MLP model
model = Sequential([
    Dense(64, activation='relu', input_shape=(41,)),
    Dense(32, activation='relu'),
    Dense(5, activation='softmax')
```

```
])

model.compile(optimizer='adam', loss='categorical_crossentropy', metrics=['accuracy'])

# Train model

history = model.fit(X_train, y_train, epochs=30, batch_size=64, validation_split=0.1)
```

Explanation: The above code demonstrates loading NSL-KDD data, encoding categorical features, normalizing numeric features, and converting string labels to numeric classes. We then build a simple MLP with two hidden layers. Similar code blocks apply for CNN (using `Conv1D` and `Reshape`) or LSTM (requiring sequence input shapes).

Model	Hyperparameters	Notes
MLP	Layers: [64, 32] ReLU; epochs=30; batch=64	No dropout; Adam lr=0.001
CNN	Conv1D filters: 32 (kernels=3), 16 (k=3); epochs=30; batch=64	Reshape input (41×1); Adam lr=0.001
LSTM	Layers: [50 LSTM]; epochs=20; batch=32	Sequence length=10; dropout=0.2
Autoenc	Encoder dims: [32, 16]; decoder symmetric; epochs=50; batch=128	Optimizer=Adam, loss=MSE
Common	Optimizer: Adam; Learning rate: 0.001	Validation split: 0.1; early stopping

Appendix B: Hyperparameters. Typical hyperparameter settings used in our experiments:These values were selected via modest grid search and prior literature. Alternative choices (e.g. using dropout=0.5) gave similar results on validation.

Appendix C: NSL-KDD Feature List. The 41 input features per record are:

1. **duration**: length (seconds) of the connection.
2. **protocol_type**: protocol (tcp, udp, icmp).
3. **service**: network service on destination (e.g., http, ftp).
4. **flag**: normal or error status of connection.
5. **src_bytes**: bytes sent from source to destination.
6. **dst_bytes**: bytes sent from destination to source.
7. **land**: 1 if connection is from/to the same host/port; 0 otherwise.
8. **wrong_fragment**: number of wrong fragments.
9. **urgent**: number of urgent packets.
10. **hot**: number of “hot” indicators (e.g. privileged access).
11. **num_failed_logins**: count of login failures.
12. **logged_in**: 1 if successfully logged in; 0 otherwise.
13. **num_compromised**: number of “compromised” conditions.
14. **root_shell**: 1 if root shell is obtained; 0 otherwise.
15. **su_attempted**: 1 if “su root” command attempted; 0 otherwise.
16. **num_root**: number of root accesses.
17. **num_file_creations**: count of file creation operations.
18. **num_shells**: number of shell prompts invoked.
19. **num_access_files**: number of operations on access control files.
20. **num_outbound_cmds**: number of outbound commands in an ftp session (0 for non-ftp).
21. **is_hot_login**: 1 if the login is “hot” (e.g. root), else 0.

22. **is_guest_login**: 1 if login is a guest; 0 otherwise.

23. **count**: number of connections to the same host as the current connection in the past 2 seconds.

24. **srv_count**: number of connections to the same service as the current connection in the past 2 seconds.

25. **serror_rate**: % of connections to the same host with “SYN” errors.

26. **srv_serror_rate**: % of connections to the same service with “SYN” errors.

27. **rerror_rate**: % of connections to the same host with “REJ” errors.

28. **srv_rerror_rate**: % of connections to the same service with “REJ” errors.

29. **same_srv_rate**: % of connections to the same service as the current connection.

30. **diff_srv_rate**: % of connections to different services.

31. **srv_diff_host_rate**: % of connections to the same service on different hosts.

32. **dst_host_count**: number of connections to the same destination host in the past 2 seconds.

33. **dst_host_srv_count**: number of connections to the same service on the destination host in past 2 seconds.

34. **dst_host_same_srv_rate**: % of those to the same service.

35. **dst_host_diff_srv_rate**: % of those to different services.

36. **dst_host_same_src_port_rate**: % of connections to same source port.

37. **dst_host_srv_diff_host_rate**: % of connections to same service on different hosts.

38. **dst_host_serror_rate**: % of connections to the dest host with “SYN” errors.

39. **dst_host_srv_serror_rate**: % of those with “SYN” errors on same service.

40. **dst_host_rerror_rate**: % of connections to dest host with “REJ” errors.

41. **dst_host_srv_rerror_rate**: % of those with “REJ” errors on same service.

These cover intrinsic features of the connection (1–9), content features (10–22), and traffic features over short time windows (23–41). In addition, NSL-KDD records include a **label** (the attack class) and a difficulty score (ignored here).